



surya namaskar. It's much more complex. What you see here is the pinnacle of what the human body can do," he said.

Each event was overseen by a panel of 13 judges, including five primary judges. "They are known as key or difficulty judges," Umang explained. "They evaluate each *asana* based on how accurately it is performed, how long it is held, and how smoothly and correctly the athlete enters and exits the posture. There is also an artistic judge, who assesses the quality of the athlete's transitions from one posture to another and from one position on the performance area to another."

This is where the Code of Points came into play. "Everything is in there — all the *asanas*, around 230 to 270 of them, their gradation, the rules, judging criteria, holding times, balance requirements, how to enter and exit an *asana*, and how performances are scored," said Udit, adding: "Before the event, we conducted numerous training sessions with international coaches and athletes so that they fully understood the competition framework and expectations."

The tournament represented one of the many steps towards fulfilling the larger vision of taking Yogasana to the biggest stage of all — the Olympics.

With India's bid to host the 2036 Games gathering momentum, Udit viewed the journey as a long build rather than a quick breakthrough. The ambition, he said, was scale — pursued "step by step" through federated systems, continental championships and television coverage.

"For Yogasana to grow globally, what will be required is a lot of education, a lot of coaches and a lot of technical officials," said Udit. "We are relying on the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), the Ministry of External Affairs and our consulates in those countries. Then the road becomes structured. We have to make Yogasana sustainable, economically stable and economically rewarding to the ecosystem."

For all the talk of global expansion, however, the competition underlined just how far ahead India remains in the sport's development. The host nation finished atop the table with 114 medals, including 102

Host supremacy: India dominated the standings with 114 medals, including 102 golds.

by Japan that had three golds. Nepal finished second overall with 52 medals.

Chandrakant Mishra, chief coach of the Indian team, outlined the preparations behind the campaign. "We prepared for a month for this tournament, including a national camp in Ahmedabad. Due to our familiarity with both the practice environment and the climate, we had an advantage," he said. That said, Mishra was quick to acknowledge the strengths of the competition. "The African athletes were more flexible than the Indians," he noted. "Where they fell short was in skill and technique, despite possessing greater strength. The Jordanian and Sri Lankan teams also impressed."

As routines ended, athletes held their final poses for a few moments longer before stepping off the mat. By the time the inaugural World Yogasana Championships drew to a close, they had left behind more than a medal table. Yogasana's Olympic ambitions may still be years away, but at the EKA Arena, it looked determined to not lose its balance on the way there.

The author was at the event on invitation by World Yogasana and Yogasana Bharat

